Israel: Opposition-led government now likely

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Given their desire to avoid uncertain early elections and greater openness to working with ultra-Orthodox figures previously aligned with Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, opposition parties are now likely to form a government (60% odds).
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Former Israel Defense Forces chief of staff Gadi Eisenkot is best positioned to form what would probably be a minority government that would have a less close relationship with President Donald Trump, focus on repairing ties with Washington, and oversee a gradual reduction in the roughly $4 billion in annual US military aid.
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Early elections remain possible (30%), in large part because Avigdor Lieberman, a key opposition leader, has steadfastly opposed any government reliant on Arab parties, though he may compromise on this issue to avoid electoral losses and a national unity government with Netanyahu (10%).

Opposition government is looking more likely (60%). Israeli President Isaac Herzog will likely tap Eisenkot—nominated by the parties holding the most seats in the incoming Knesset following the October elections—by 11 November to form the next government. Divisions among Jewish and Arab opposition parties and prospective ultra-Orthodox partners make a minority government more likely (50%) than a majority one (10%).

New elections could hurt the opposition because it may not repeat its strong performance and voter turnout. At the same time, votes wasted on right-wing parties that failed to cross the electoral threshold may flow back to Likud, and a more mobilized Netanyahu bloc could further erode the opposition’s seat count.

Eisenkot may believe he can overcome objections by some opposition leaders to working with Arab or ultra-Orthodox parties by building momentum even before a government is formed by securing the Knesset speakership when the new legislature convenes on 10 November and advancing an opposition

agenda that includes barring Netanyahu from the premiership, creating a state commission of inquiry on the 07 October 2023 attack, and advancing ultra-Orthodox conscription. Amir Ohana, the Likud Knesset speaker, could attempt to delay this maneuver but would be unlikely to ultimately stop it.

Ultra-Orthodox parties such as the uncommitted United Torah Judaism may be willing to back an opposition-led government despite their long association with the Netanyahu bloc. Netanyahu failed to deliver on his pledge to exempt ultra-Orthodox men from military service, and the perceived inevitability of conscription may now push at least one of these parties to work with the opposition to soften its implementation. Sensitivities regarding the inclusion of ultra-Orthodox parties in the opposition coalition are significant but less than those regarding the Arab parties.

Early elections remain a possibility (30%). Lieberman, leader of the opposition party Yisrael Beiteinu, is staunchly opposed to joining an opposition-led government that relies on Arab parties, concerned that it would harm his standing with his right-wing Jewish base in the event of early elections. He anticipates that a minority government could not withstand divisions over near-term security operations in the West Bank and Gaza and that its likely collapse would allow Netanyahu to make major gains in the next election. However, Lieberman and other opposition leaders may still compromise because failing to form a government before another vote would be very damaging.

No signs of opposition move toward national unity government (10%). Should Eisenkot fail to form a government, Netanyahu—whose Likud party won the most seats in the election—will have an opportunity. Herzog, who has been a strong advocate of a compromise among the mainstream Jewish Zionist parties, could also encourage Eisenkot and Netanyahu to form a unity government. However, the opposition has not softened its objection to working with Netanyahu.

Netanyahu is pushing for a new round of US-Israeli escalation against Iran, both to cement his legacy with an Iranian defeat and to improve the odds of a unity government. The opposition is likely to view such an escalation as a political ploy, and it would not dramatically improve the odds of a unity government.

US midterm results signal growing likelihood of Israel military aid cuts. An Eisenkot-led government would focus on repairing strained US ties and work to improve Israel’s international standing by engaging more in talks to end the Gaza conflict and avoiding actions that exacerbate West Bank tensions. His role in revamping US-Israel relations would probably include overseeing the gradual reduction of roughly $4 billion in annual US military aid during the remainder of Trump’s term.

On 3 November, the day of US midterm elections, Trump announced that the US would end its roughly $4 billion in annual military aid to Israel at the end of the year. The next day, after the Democrats won both chambers of Congress, Vice President JD Vance noted US voters’ desire to revise the relationship with Israel.

Although existing financial obligations related to Israeli arms purchases may preclude an immediate aid cut-off, these comments—unexpected in Israel and damaging to Netanyahu—indicate that the annual US military assistance package to Israel will likely end in its current form and give way to a security relationship centered more on commercial sales and cooperation on technology development and intelligence sharing.

Israel can absorb the end of this aid but will face short-term fiscal challenges from a significant increase in its annual defense spending. These will add to existing pressures, including a top-heavy economy, competing budgetary priorities, and efforts to better integrate the rapidly growing ultra-Orthodox

population that faces structural barriers to economic participation.

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